streamed into the room, casting a disfigured shadow of hers on the floor.

She had her head resting on her right hand. I was not sure if she was sleeping, she was facing away from me. I did not want to wake her up if she was sleeping, but I was longing to console her, get consoled in her embrace.

I called out her name. Then a second time. Did she move?

I switched on the bedroom lamp.

'Meena,' I called again, this time loud. 'I am back.'

She turned around slowly, raised her head and stayed still, staring into my eyes. She had a strange expression, as if she was watching me doing something horrible. Then she let out a shriek that I had never heard—from a human or an animal. It ran through the house, woke up the neighbourhood and sent everyone at home rushing upstairs. It lasted a few seconds. Then she fell silent again, still staring at me.

I sat down and rested her head on my lap. I ran my fingers through her hair. I called out her name, softly.

She was silent. I felt her tears wet my thighs.

PSLV FLIES, SO DOES MY RESIGNATION LETTER

'My part worked well, the second stage.'

It may be preposterous to say the US prompted a Kerala police inspector to arrest a Maldivian woman to implicate ISRO scientists and stall India's progress in space science. The inspector, a virtually insignificant character in the drama, only had his personal motives in threatening and arresting Mariam Rasheeda. But later, when the police discovered ISRO scientist Sasikumaran's phone number in Rasheeda's diary, the US struck through their cohorts in Indian IB.

A few IB officers including its then joint directors M K Dhar and Rattan Sehgal, were only too eager to play along for obvious benefits. It so happened that when the ISRO spy case broke out, a faction within the